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economy - tax rebate proposal for gas could help taxpayers

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Californians are still letting out a collective groan when seeing the prices at their local gas station, but some relief could be on the way. Several California assembly members are expected to announce a proposal for a $400 gas rebate Thursday morning.

The average price of unleaded gas in California went up by a cent Thursday from $5.77 to $5.78 a gallon, and is 10 cents more expensive than it was a week ago, according to the American Automobile Association. The national average price of a gallon of gas hit a peak of $4.33 on Friday before falling one cent and dropping to $4.28 Thursday — two cents cheaper than it was on Wednesday.

Gas prices have continued to rise in the Golden State, despite the national average and crude oil prices on a downward. In San Francisco, the average went up two cents to $5.90 a gallon Thursday while prices increased from $5.77 to $5.79 in San Jose. Elsewhere in the Bay Area, prices rose from $5.81 to $5.82 in Oakland, $5.75 to $5.77 in Santa Cruz/Watsonville and stayed at $5.89 a gallon in San Rafael.

Assembly Democrats, led by Assemblywoman Cottie Petrie-Norris, are expected to introduce a proposal to use $9 billion of the state's multibillion dollar budget surplus to send every California taxpayer a $400 gas rebate. If passed, the rebate would also go to Californians who don't drive or own cars, due to the hike of living expenses.

"Tomorrow we'll be unveiling a proposal to provide much-needed direct relief to Californians facing high gas prices," wrote Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel on Twitter. "Unlike other proposals, this will ensure we help California families, not oil companies or foreign dictators."

The national average soared past the $4 per gallon mark earlier this month and surpassed the record high of $4.103, which was reached in 2008. Gas prices have swung upward after sanctions on Russian commodities during the ongoing Russian invasion of Ukraine.

Crude oil prices dropped down to $96 per barrel this week and the falling price could cause the national average to fall 35 to 55 cents

per gallon over the next three to five weeks, according to Patrick De Haan, head of petroleum analysis for GasBuddy, on Twitter.

Motorists in California pay the highest fuel prices in the country, partially due to higher taxes for environmental regulations and infrastructure, costing drivers an extra $1.19 a gallon, according to a recent report. There is also a "mystery" surcharge, called a "phantom tax" that raises prices higher in California due to higher profit-taking from gas retailers, according to one analysis.

San Jose's east side has some of the lowest gas prices in the region, in addition to other portions of the South Bay and East Bay, according to a map of Bay Area prices from GasBuddy. A gas station called Moe's Stop were offering regular fuel at $5.16 a gallon Thursday at two places in San Jose. Meanwhile, one station is charging $5.25 a gallon in San Leandro while another in Oakland's Fruitvale District was offering gas at $5.29 a gallon. Some of the most expensive prices were in San Francisco and along the Peninsula, with one station charging $5.89 a gallon.

In the wake of high gas prices, AAA has offered some tips to try and save fuel:

• Slow down and go easy on the brake. Speeding wastes fuel, and so does hard braking and acceleration. Clear out your trunk. Carrying heavy items reduces fuel mileage.

• Avoid idling, if you can.

• Inflate your tires to the proper air pressure.

• Consolidate trips and drive less. Use the most fuel-efficient car in your household to run errands.

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